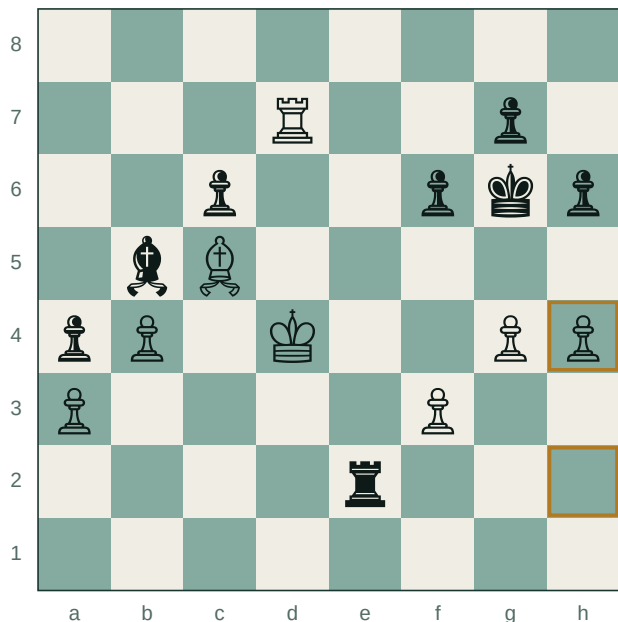


Skewers: Black, move 39

Skewers

Black to move



Previous move: 39.h4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Rd2+ 40. Kc3 Rxd7

39...Rd2+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **40.Kc3**.

40...Rxd7 The rook captures the rook on d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 8 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from +0 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The defender may block, capture the attacker, or protect the rear piece while moving the front one. Alignment alone is not enough.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A skewer puts the more important target in front. When that target moves, a piece behind it may be lost. Checks make the geometry especially forcing.

HOW TO LOOK

Search ranks, files, and diagonals where two enemy pieces line up. Calculate the first target's legal responses.

The defending king is on d4. Geometrically undefended: rook on d7. Check for tactical protection.